

Research Ethics & Informed Consent

The signed Ethics Agreement is a hard gate before any data collection

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Research ethics govern the responsible treatment of participants and data. Before any primary data is collected, EUBS requires the student to discuss the ethical dimensions of the research with the promoter and sign the Ethics Discussion and Agreement. The core obligations are informed consent, the right to withdraw, confidentiality and anonymity, secure data protection, and conducting the research professionally so as to protect participants and the institution's reputation.

THE FOUR PILLARS (EUBS FORM)

(1) Rights of participants: what participation involves and the right to withdraw. (2) Confidentiality: who accesses findings; anonymity of participants and organisations. (3) Data protection: how data is gathered, stored and destroyed. (4) Institutional reputation: professional conduct throughout, including all written communication.

INFORMED CONSENT

Participants must understand the purpose, what is involved, how data will be used, and that they may withdraw without penalty — and agree before data is collected. Consent is documented (a signed or recorded consent form), retained, and covers recording, storage and anonymisation.

Ethics is a gate, not a chapter to backfill. The signed Ethics Agreement must be in place BEFORE the first interview or survey goes out. Data collected before sign-off cannot be ethically used. If your methods change materially, you must re-discuss the ethical issues with your promoter — the form commits you to this.

Obligation	What it requires
Informed consent	Understand + agree before taking part
Right to withdraw	Leave at any point, no penalty
Confidentiality	Control access; anonymise identities
Data protection	Secure storage; planned destruction
Professional conduct	Protect participants and institution

SIGN BEFORE COLLECTING

No data collection may begin until the Ethics Agreement is signed. This is non-negotiable and checked at review.

KEEP CONSENT FORMS

Retain signed consent for every participant. 'Findings but no consent evidence' is both an ethics and an authenticity problem.

RE-DISCUSS IF CHANGED

If the method changes, revisit ethics with your promoter. The form obliges you to; silent changes breach the agreement.

Common pitfalls. (1) Collecting data before the Agreement is signed. (2) No documented informed consent. (3) Identifiable participants or organisations left un-anonymised. (4) No data-protection or destruction plan. (5) Material method changes never re-discussed with the promoter.

REFERENCES

Bryman, A. and Bell, E. (2015) *Business Research Methods*. 4th edn. Oxford: Oxford University Press. · Saunders, M., Lewis, P. and Thornhill, A. (2019) *Research Methods for Business Students*. 8th edn. Harlow: Pearson. · Follow the EUBS Ethics Discussion and Agreement requirement.